

piece of the healthcare journey – which is building an interface that benefits not just the insurer or hospital but also the end user, the patient.

Medi Assist insists that every transaction is mirrored in real time across everyone's dashboards. "The hospital, the insurer, the agent, the member, everybody and us, we see the same thing in real time," according to Satish Gidugu. In an industry infamous for secrecy and finger-pointing, needless to say this transparency is a breath of fresh air.

Of course, to make all of this work, there's also scale involved in the equation. "We work with more than 12,000 corporates... more than 30,000 hospitals, all the major health insurance companies as such," Dhruv Rastogi notes. Integration at that level requires robust data governance and standardized access controls, he notes. But once that's in place, you unlock the potential for real-time analytics, faster reimbursements, and an overall sense that maybe health insurance doesn't have to be painful.

Intelligently cutting down hospital discharge time

One direct perk of all the advanced AI baked into Medi Assist's tech stack is a predictive model that gauges a patient's out-of-pocket expenses before they're even given the final bill. "We spent the last couple of years working on this feature, and had multiple iterations and versions to enhance its accuracy," Satish says. The result? Some 7,000 patients have been discharged quickly, without the usual hours-long suspense waiting for final payment clearance. That's a big deal for patients who might otherwise spend unnecessary hours in hospital premises, worrying about medical costs or worse.

"In the end, it's about building that frictionless moment of truth, so you can just walk out," Dhruv adds. The AI basically cross-references your claim, hospital tariff, policy coverage, plus any past data to project the final tab. That shortens wait times, cuts overhead for hospitals, and fosters a sense of trust that's historically lacking in the Indian

medical insurance and healthcare sector at large. Additionally, with so many tie-ups with Medicare providers, Medi Assist processes nearly a quarter of all health insurance claims in India, Satish says, and "85 percent of hospital-submitted claims processed through an electronic workflow," he emphasises. If you think about the ripple effect, that's thousands of hours saved daily across hospitals, insurers, and patients and their families.

But according to Satish, it's not just about digitising a failing system – it's re-engineering the entire claims workflow. By standardising data, training AI to handle everything from suspicious billing codes to minor coverage details, and enforcing real-time transparency, they're arguably turning an archaic ecosystem into a modern, data-driven enterprise of the 21st century.

Building the future of Indian healthcare

Both Satish and Dhruv sound bullish about the future, when I asked them about looking ahead at what the future of Indian healthcare might look like. With the Indian government's push for digital identity (ABHA IDs) and open data initiatives, the stage is set for deeper integration, they say. Think of an environment where your coverage data merges with your telemedicine app, your e-pharmacy, and possibly your wearable device. That's when insurance stops being a hush-hush black box of complexities and denial, and evolves into a truly personalised, dynamic system.

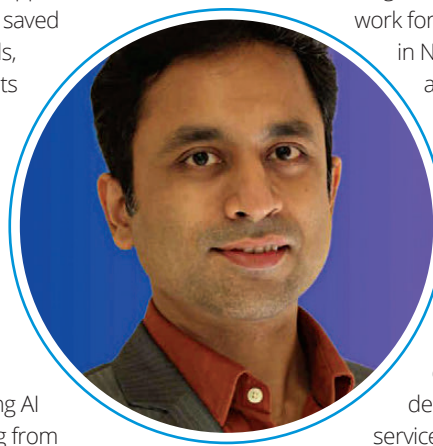
"Can our health insurance plans be customised and personalized?" wonders Dhruv, pointing out that technology can easily differentiate your risk profile from someone else's. If you're someone who never touches a cigarette, hits the

gym regularly, or has a family history that suggests minimal risk, why not a plan that reflects your lifestyle? That might finally turn health coverage from a reluctant purchase into something that actively invests in your well-being. And to kickstart that process, Medi Assist along with Boston Consulting Group (BCG)

unveiled a groundbreaking framework for "Borderless Health" in November 2024. Still at a conceptual stage, the Borderless Health framework is Medi Assist's vision to eliminate healthcare disparities by creating a data-driven, technology-enabled model for delivering healthcare services. At the core of this new approach is the "Health JAM Trinity," which consists of three key components – Joined Health Data, Automation, and Mobile-Enabled Healthcare.

These pillars will enable more efficient, equitable, and accessible healthcare services across India, according to Medi Assist. "Achieving universal cashless healthcare by 2047 will require coordinated efforts and collaboration among healthcare providers, insurers, employers, and policymakers," emphasises Satish. As I reach the end of my conversation with Satish and Dhruv, I can't help but wonder at Medi Assist's story being a testament to how even the most deeply entrenched, paper-heavy industries can transform with the right blend of AI, data, and willpower.

"I don't know how you do your job, protecting the milk and keeping the cat happy," jokes Satish, recalling a comment made by a longtime industry observer. But that's precisely the challenge Medi Assist has taken up, of bridging the needs of insurers, hospitals, and patients with minimal friction. And the difference it could make for millions of Indians who rely on insurance not just to cover a bill but to finally offer peace of mind. **d**



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